

Complaints and Dispute Resolution Policy

Document Reference: DC-POL-009

Document Ref:	DC-POL-009
Version:	v2.3
Effective Date:	01 January 2025
Review Date:	01 January 2026
Approved By:	Chief Executive Officer
Department:	Customer Services

1. Purpose and Commitment

DataCompany Housing Management is committed to delivering high-quality housing management services. Where we fall short of expectations, we want to hear from you and put things right as quickly as possible. This policy sets out how tenants and other persons affected by DataCompany's services can make a complaint, how complaints are handled, and what options are available if a complaint is not resolved to the complainant's satisfaction.

We define a complaint as an expression of dissatisfaction about the standard of service, action or lack of action by DataCompany or its staff, agents or contractors. A complaint is different from a service request (such as a repair report), which is handled through the relevant service channel.

2. Who Can Make a Complaint

- Any current DataCompany tenant or authorised representative (e.g. a solicitor acting on their behalf).
- A former tenant, in relation to matters arising during their tenancy.
- A member of the public affected by the actions of DataCompany or its contractors.
- A prospective tenant, regarding the letting or application process.

Anonymous complaints will be considered where the information provided is sufficiently detailed to permit investigation, but DataCompany cannot provide a response or outcome to an anonymous complainant.

3. How to Submit a Complaint

Method	Contact Details	Acknowledgement Time
Online Portal	portal.datacompany.co.zw (Complaints section)	Automated acknowledgement within 1 hour
Email	complaints@datacompany.co.zw	1 working day
Telephone	+263 4 700 100	Verbal acknowledgement during call; written confirmation within 2 working days
In Writing	DataCompany Housing Management, Harare (marked Complaints)	3 working days
In Person	DataCompany Offices, Harare (appointment recommended)	Verbal acknowledgement; written confirmation within 2 working days

4. The Complaints Process

4.1 Stage 1 - Informal Resolution

All complaints are first handled at Stage 1 by the relevant service team manager. The manager will contact the complainant within 3 working days to understand the issue, explain what happened, and agree on a resolution. Stage 1 aims to resolve complaints quickly and informally. A written summary of the Stage 1 decision is provided within 10 working days of the complaint being received.

4.2 Stage 2 - Formal Review

Where the complainant is not satisfied with the Stage 1 outcome, they may request a Stage 2 review within 20 working days of receiving the Stage 1 decision. Stage 2 is conducted by a senior manager or Head of Department not previously involved in the complaint. A full written response is provided within 20 working days of the Stage 2 request being received, with an extension of up to 10 further working days if the investigation requires it (the complainant will be notified of any extension).

4.3 Stage 3 - Executive Review

Where the complainant remains unsatisfied after Stage 2, they may request an Executive Review conducted by the Chief Executive Officer or a designated executive. This is the final stage of DataCompany's internal complaints process. The complainant will receive a final written response within 30 working days.

5. Timescales Summary

Stage	Trigger	Response Deadline
Stage 1 - Informal Resolution	Complaint received	Written decision within 10 working days
Stage 2 - Formal Review	Escalation requested within 20 days of Stage 1 outcome	Written decision within 20 working days
Stage 3 - Executive Review	Escalation requested within 20 days of Stage 2 outcome	Written decision within 30 working days
External Resolution	After completion of Stage 3	By agreement with external body

6. External Resolution Options

If a complainant has exhausted all three stages of DataCompany's internal process and remains dissatisfied, the following external options are available:

- Zimbabwe Housing Tribunal: The Housing Tribunal has jurisdiction over residential tenancy disputes and can adjudicate on complaints regarding rent, deposits, conditions and evictions.
- Mediation Service: DataCompany supports the use of accredited independent mediators for complex disputes. Costs are shared equally unless otherwise agreed.
- Legal Action: Any party retains the right to seek legal remedy through the courts at any stage of the process, independent of this policy.
- Regulatory Complaint: Complaints about DataCompany's conduct as a housing provider may be submitted to the Zimbabwe Ministry of National Housing.

7. Confidentiality and Record Keeping

All complaints are treated in confidence. Information shared during a complaint investigation will only be disclosed to those directly involved in investigating or resolving the complaint, or where required by law. Complaint records are retained for seven years. DataCompany uses aggregated, anonymised complaint data to identify trends and improve services.